

Chapter 8

What He Built

Monday morning settled over Frankfurt beneath a pale grey sky.

The city was already awake.

Cars moved steadily through the streets, trains disappeared into underground stations, and the glass buildings along the business district reflected the cold morning light.

Among them stood one of the city's most closely watched investment firms.

Veyron Holdings.

The company occupied the upper floors of a modern glass tower.

Inside, everything moved with quiet precision.

Assistants crossed the corridors carrying files.

Executives spoke in low voices.

Phones rang.

Meetings began and ended.

Nothing seemed rushed.

Yet everyone knew that decisions made inside those offices could move millions in a matter of minutes.

On the top floor, a meeting was already underway.

Roman sat at the head of the long conference table.

A presentation filled the screen behind him.

Property valuations.

Projected returns.

Market forecasts.

Risk assessments.

He listened without interrupting.

The presentation finally ended.

The room fell silent.

Roman looked at the man standing beside the screen.

"You're expecting a twelve percent return."

"Yes."

"Based on what?"

The man hesitated.

"Market growth."

Roman glanced down at the report in front of him.

"That's an expectation."

He turned a page.

"Where is your risk calculation?"

The man looked at the screen.

Roman waited.

When no answer came, he closed the file.

"Do it again."

"Today?"

"Tomorrow morning."

The man nodded.

Roman looked around the table.

"Never build a strategy around what you hope will happen."

His voice remained calm.

"Build it around what could go wrong."

No one argued.

Roman stood.

"That's all."

The meeting ended.

People gathered their files and began leaving.

One of the senior directors stayed behind.

"Roman."

Roman looked at him.

"The board wants an update on Frankfurt."

"Which part?"

"The expansion."

Roman walked toward the windows.

"The numbers?"

"Good."

"The risks?"

"Manageable."

Roman glanced over his shoulder.

"Then what's the problem?"

"The board thinks we're moving too quickly."

A faint smile touched Roman's face.

"Three years ago they thought we were moving too slowly."

The director smiled.

"Fair enough."

Roman looked back toward the city.

"They can review the numbers again."

"And if they still disagree?"

"Then they can disagree."

The director laughed quietly.

"You've changed."

Roman's expression remained unreadable.

"Maybe."

Three years earlier, Veyron had been a very different company.

It hadn't belonged to Roman.

The business had been built years before he ever entered it, once respected for its investments across Europe.

But poor management had slowly weakened it.

Several bad acquisitions had tied up its money.

Some major investments had failed.

Senior executives had lost the confidence of investors.

The company was still valuable.

But its direction was almost gone.

Most people looking at it saw a business that was slowly falling apart.

Roman saw something else.

Potential.

He didn't build Veyron from nothing.

He bought into what was already there.

Then he changed nearly everything that wasn't working.

He replaced the management team.

Sold properties that were draining money.

Cut unnecessary expenses.

Moved the company away from short-term speculation and toward long-term investments.

He expanded its real-estate portfolio.

Created international partnerships.

And, most importantly...

he stopped treating every opportunity as something worth taking.

Three years later, the company had become almost unrecognizable.

Its value had multiplied.

Its name carried influence.

Its investments reached across several European markets.

People who had once considered the company a declining business now competed to work with it.

Roman hadn't inherited the success.

He had taken something damaged...

and made it stronger.

His assistant entered his office carrying a dark folder.

"Mr. Ashford."

Roman looked up from his laptop.

"Yes?"

"The Northbridge proposal."

She placed the folder on his desk.

The name on the cover caught his attention.

Northbridge Group.

For a second...

he didn't move.

His fingers rested against the folder.

Then he opened it.

The first pages contained financial information.

The next pages outlined the proposed development.

Then the names of the people involved.

Roman's eyes moved down the page.

Until they stopped.

Elara Hayes.

The room seemed quieter.

He read the name again.

Not because he had forgotten it.

He hadn't.

His eyes remained on it for a moment longer than necessary.

Then he turned the page.

His assistant noticed nothing.

"The investment would give us a significant position in the project," she explained.

"How significant?"

"Enough that Northbridge would need us for the next phase."

Roman closed the folder.

"Need isn't the same as dependence."

She nodded.

"The board believes this could become one of our most important Frankfurt investments."

Roman looked at the folder again.

"When is the meeting?"

"Tomorrow at ten."

"Confirm it."

She paused.

"With Northbridge?"

"Yes."

"Should I inform them that you'll be attending personally?"

Roman was silent for a moment.

Then shook his head.

"No."

"Why?"

"I want to see how they negotiate before they know exactly what we're prepared to offer."

She nodded.

"Understood."

She turned toward the door.

"One more thing."

Roman looked up.

"Yes?"

"The Northbridge team sent a revised profile for their representative."

She handed him a tablet.

Roman looked at the screen.

Elara's professional profile appeared.

Her recent work.

Her education.

Her position.

He read through it carefully.

Then he lowered the tablet.

"Send me the full proposal."

"I already did."

"No."

He looked at her.

"Send me everything."

She nodded.

"Of course."

When the door closed behind her, Roman remained still.

His eyes returned to the tablet.

To the same name.

He didn't smile.

He didn't frown.

He simply looked at the screen for a few seconds before turning it off.

Then he placed the tablet on the desk.

Carefully.

As if nothing had happened.

The afternoon passed quickly.

Roman moved from one meeting to another.

He reviewed investments.

Signed documents.

Approved a property acquisition.

Rejected a proposal that didn't meet the company's standards.

To everyone around him, he appeared completely focused.

Controlled.

Untouched by anything outside the business in front of him.

Only once did his attention drift.

His assistant had mentioned tomorrow's meeting.

Northbridge.

Frankfurt.

Elara.

He didn't allow himself to think further.

There was no reason to.

At least...

that's what he told himself.

That evening, Roman returned to his apartment overlooking the city.

It was quiet.

Minimal.

Everything had its place.

He removed his watch and placed it on the table.

Then his phone vibrated.

Another message.

Tomorrow, 10:00 a.m. Northbridge Group.

Roman read it.

His thumb remained on the screen.

For a few seconds, he did nothing.

Then he locked the phone.

He walked toward the window.

Frankfurt glittered beneath him.

Three years ago, he had left this city with almost nothing except questions he could never answer.

Now...

he was returning with a company powerful enough to sit across the table from the people who had once decided his future for him.

Roman looked at his reflection in the glass.

The face staring back at him was calmer than the one he remembered.

Harder.

But not completely different.

Some parts of a person don't disappear.

They simply learn how to stay hidden.

His gaze dropped toward the watch on the table.

For a brief moment, another memory crossed his mind.

A girl laughing beside the sea.

A familiar smile.

A voice he hadn't heard in years.

Roman looked away.

Tomorrow was a business meeting.

Nothing more.

At least...

that's what it was supposed to be.

He turned off the lights.

And left the city behind the glass.